Introduction

The National Museum of Singapore's *Modern Colony* exhibit is an immersive sensory experience that is carefully structured across space, time and sound. However, I posit that *Modern Colony*, through the very act of representing these differences found among the various strata of colonial society, succumbs to a certain marginalization of class. This paper aims to critically analyze the choice of object, structure, auditory and visual landscape displayed in *Modern Colony*, in light of the social narrative it poses.

Entrance

The exhibit begins at well-lit pair of cane chairs and a table backed by a house's pale façade. The text displayed on the opposite wall proudly introduces the Modern Colony exhibit, dedicating a paragraph to the influx of female immigrants that were granted new opportunities and lent "important contributions in a number of women's causes".

This notion of women's achievements is seemingly entirely forgotten once one enters the 'bungalow'. Lit up in the darkened chamber, an ornate frame containing a portrait of Song Ong Siang in a suit stands in the centre, flanked by two displays embedded in grandiose blue-gold wallpaper, showing off men's clothing. One of the displays is titled, "A Man's World – Affluent Lives", betraying the patriarchal overtones that dominated the times.

Notably, all the clothing displayed are woollen, long-sleeved suits – unsuitable to the tropical climate of Singapore. The only exception is a hat that keeps a person shielded from the heat, though the display board asserts that it was also "embraced for lending outfits a Western touch". The other accessories are Hollywood-style and opera glasses. The lack of traditional clothing makes clear that that affluent Asian men were expected to present themselves in Western

fashion. Hence, power, and by extension masculinity, was closely intertwined with Westernization.

Party Spectacle

The heart of the exhibit is an extravagant display consisting of well-dressed models arranged on a large wooden staircase, with spotlights flashing on each model in turn. The singular male model, wearing a Western suit, is centralized on the front step. The steps seem to 'look down' on the colourful women's clothes, accessories and shoes on display in glass cases along the sides. The instrumental music sets the scene a dinner party.

In contrast to the men's clothing, the women's clothing is truer to Asian origins, evident in the various styles of *cheongsam* preserved over two decades. However, fashion among the upper-class women adapted Western features through make-up, and jewellery. They also wore Western dresses, such as the golden flapper dress, a "symbol of change and increasing freedom". This range of clothing makes a powerful statement about femininity in the 1920s – caught between the East and West, traditional and 'modern'. Women were the site of contestation of progressiveness.

The easily-missed display dedicated to the working class is called "Under the Stairs", spatially and symbolically bringing out their inferiority. The small glass case is built into the stairs, inconspicuous and dimly lit. The accompanying board informs viewers that the *amahs* typically had few possessions, presumably due to their lower socio-economic status. This lack of tangible documentation given to them compared to the elite raises the question of whether their lives and history have been equally preserved.

In the Background

The chamber dedicated to women's conflicting identities is the perceived 'back' of the bungalow. The room is very dimly lit, drawing attention to a six-panel mirror with three spotlights that takes up an entire wall, creating a space for 'reflection'. The mirrors project images in tandem with a voiceover of various women narrating their experience growing up.

Though a unique and in-depth exploration of changing social institutions, the voiceover takes several minutes to complete. There is no physical display that shows the conflicting roles that women played in the household and in public, and a hurried viewer could not glean any substantial information from the shown objects, including a sewing machine, gramophone, and vanity.

Conclusion

Modern Colony makes clear that modernity translated to Westernization and was expressed differently between men and women, elite and bourgeois. Through a careful curation of objects, the exhibit traces the underpinnings of class distinctions – beginning with first men's, and later, women's expensive clothing, relegating a narrow space under the stairs for the working class and finally, dedicating a room in the back to women's shifting identities.

Modern Colony limits itself through the spatial arrangement of the *amah* display, and aural experience of the women's display, both of which run the risk of being side-lined in favour of the opulence of the party spectacle. This makes a clever statement regarding how classes were perceived, but in doing so only serves to marginalize and overlook these identities further.